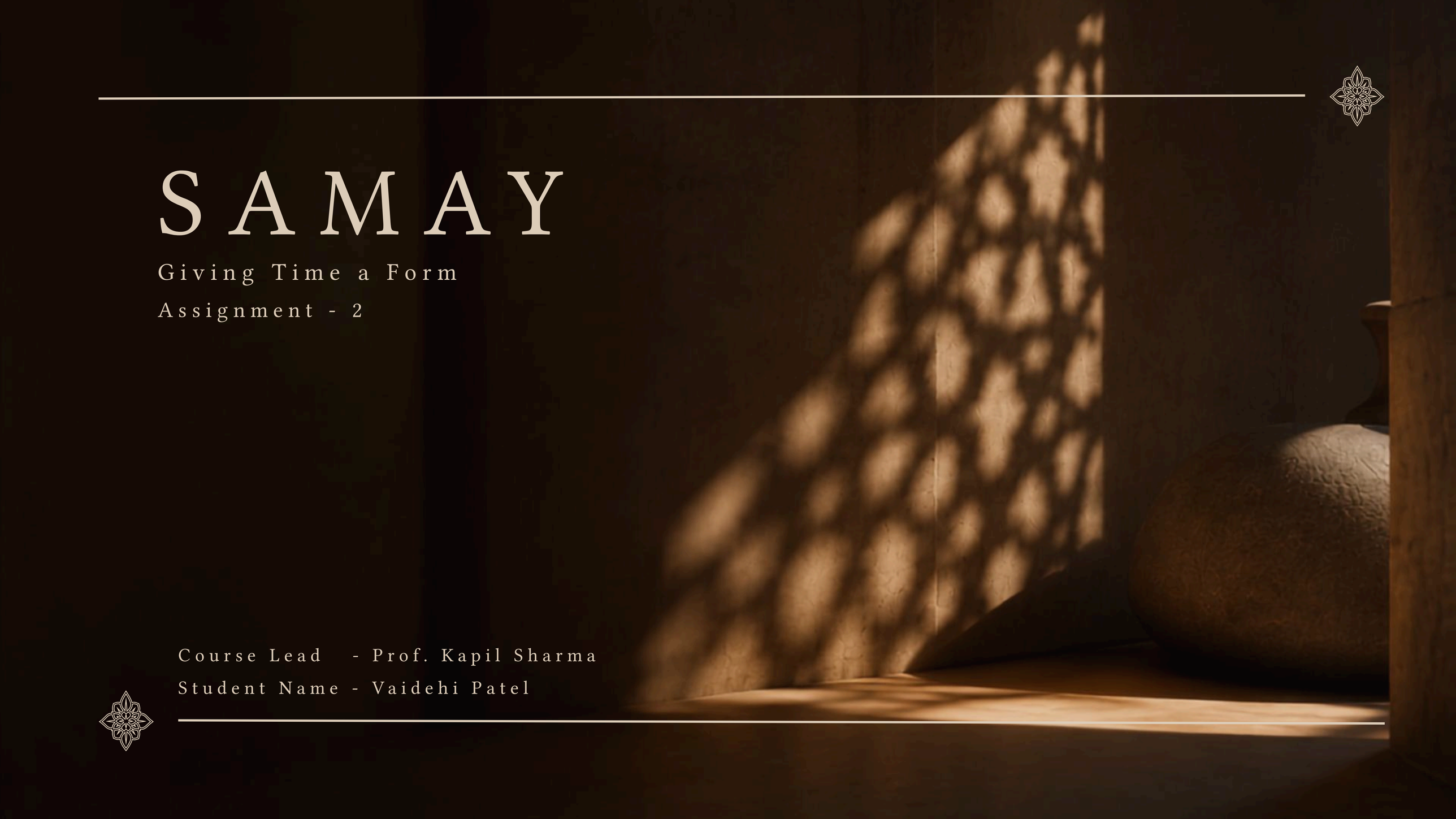
SAMAY

Giving Time a Form

Assignment - 2

Course Lead - Prof. Kapil Sharma

Student Name - Vaidehi Patel



INDIAN HERITAGE

Indian heritage is the collective legacy shaped by centuries of cultural, artistic, architectural and social practices across the Indian subcontinent.

It is not a single visual style. It is a diverse body of traditions that has evolved through different regions, communities, materials, beliefs, environments and ways of living.

ARCHITECTURE



Structures that reflect function, proportion and spirituality

CRAFT



Generations of skill passed down through hands and hearts

NATURE



Inspiration drawn from flora, fauna and natural patterns

RITUAL



Traditions that connect the material with the meaningful

MATERIAL



Local Materials shaped by climate, availability and ingenuity

PATTERN



Geometric, floral and symbolic languages of visual beauty

HERITAGE AS DESIGN

Nothing is merely decorative.

Traditional Indian objects, architecture and crafts often emerge from a combination of environment, purpose, belief, material and accumulated knowledge.

How was it made?

Knowledge of techniques, tools and craftsmanship is developed and passed through generations of makers.

Why was it made this way?

Materials are chosen based on local availability, properties, durability, climate suitability and cultural practice.



Konarch Sun Temple,
Odisha

Why does it exist?

Traditional designs respond to climate, light, ventilation, privacy, strength and practical needs.

What inspired the form?

Structures that reflect function, proportion and spirituality

What does it communicate?

Stories, beliefs, symbols and traditions are expressed through motifs, patterns and visual narratives.

SIGNIFICANCE OF TIME IN INDIAN HERITAGE

TIME HAS NEVER BEEN JUST A MEASURE.

Time in Indian heritage has often been understood through cycles, patterns and rhythms.

SUN & SHADOW



The movement of the Sun creates a natural measure of day, direction and changing light.

Represents:
Movement · Day · Passage

MOON & LUNAR CYCLES



The changing phases of the Moon have traditionally been used to understand months, festivals and ritual cycles.

Represents:
Cycles · Renewal · Rhythm

SEASONS



The recurring cycle of seasons connects time with climate, agriculture, festivals and everyday life.

Represents:
Change · Growth · Renewal

RITUAL



Many cultural practices are connected to specific times, lunar dates, seasons and astronomical events.

Represents:
Memory · Tradition · Continuity

CELESTIAL BODIES



The movement of the Sun, Moon and stars has long been observed to understand calendars, astronomy and cosmic order.

Represents:
Cosmos · Order · Continuity

LIFE CYCLES



Birth, growth, maturity, ageing and death reflect time as a continuous cycle rather than a straight line.

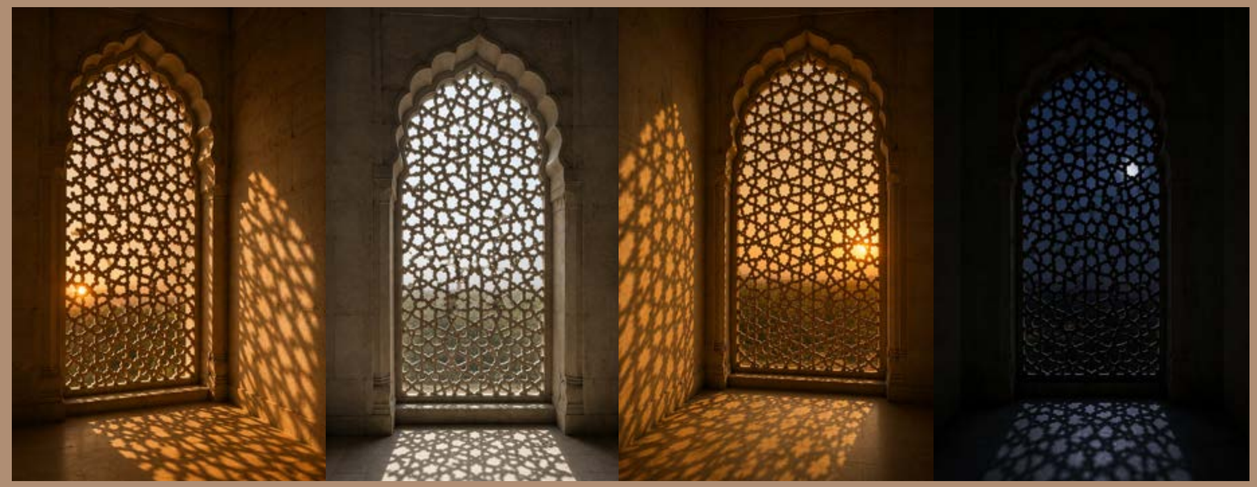
Represents:
Life · Transformation · Continuity

WHEN TIME MEETS ARCHITECTURE

JALI — A STATIC FORM THAT CHANGES WITH LIGHT

A Jali remains physically unchanged, but the light passing through its openings changes continuously as the Sun moves across the sky.

The same pattern can create different shadows, intensities and silhouettes throughout the day.



Morning **Noon** **Evening** **Night**

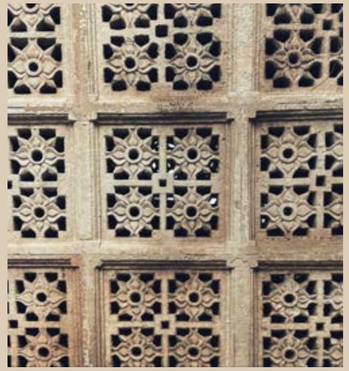
TYPES OF JAALI

Jali evolved as different architectural traditions explored the relationship between solid and void. Over time, its visual language developed from simple openings into complex geometric, floral, symbolic and regional expressions.



GEOMETRIC

Stars · Polygons · Interlocking grids



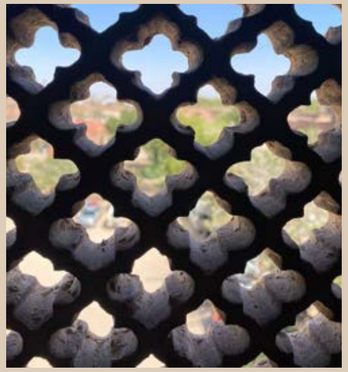
FLORAL / VEGETAL

Leaves · Flowers · Vines



TREE OF LIFE

Branches · Growth · Interconnected forms



REGIONAL

Local patterns · Materials · Craft traditions



CONTEMPORARY

Abstract · Minimal · Modular

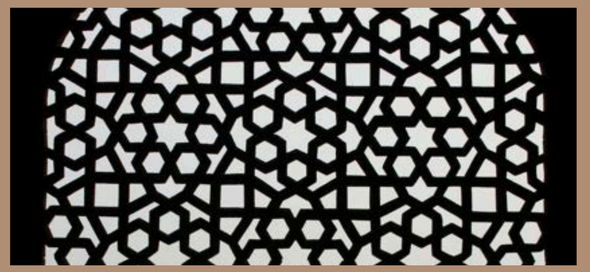
EVOLUTION OF JAALI



Early 16th Century

Perforated screens served practical purposes such as light, ventilation and privacy.

Visual language:
Simple geometric openings



16th–17th Century

Jalis became highly refined through complex systems of stars, polygons, hexagons and interlocking geometry.

Visual language:
Geometric · Symmetrical · Repetitive



16th–17th Century

Branching forms create interconnected compositions associated with growth, continuity and natural order.

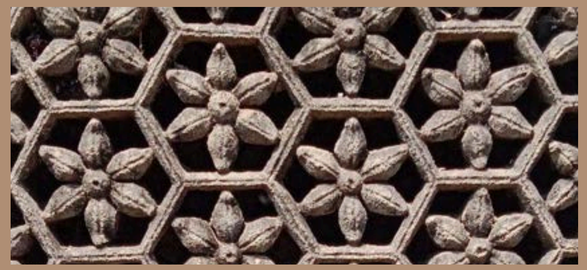
Visual language:
Branching · Organic · Symbolic



20th–21st Century

The Jali moves beyond traditional architecture into interiors, screens, furniture and contemporary design.

Visual language:
Abstract · Minimal · Modular



Later Periods

Jali traditions were adapted across regional architectures, creating variations in pattern, scale, material and ornament.

Visual language:
Local · Crafted · Diverse



17th Century

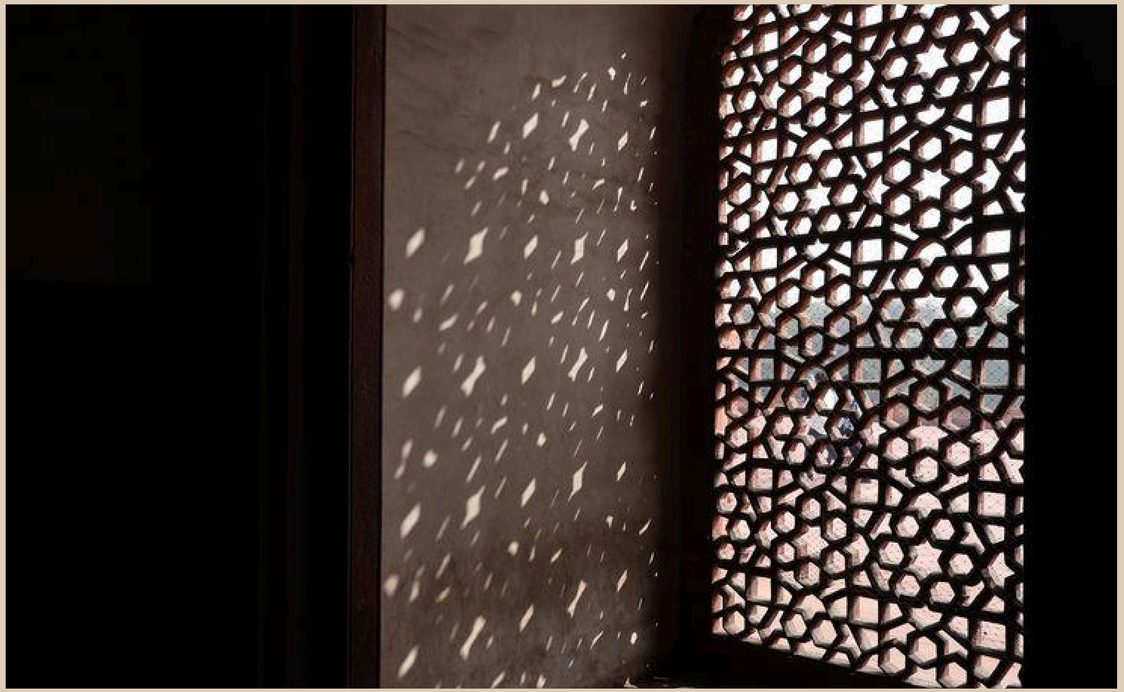
Geometric structures increasingly incorporated flowers, leaves and vegetal motifs, creating a softer and more organic character.

Visual language:
Organic · Flowing · Botanical

JALI: THE LANGUAGE OF SOLID & VOID

A Jali is created by carefully balancing solid material and open space.
What is removed becomes just as important as what remains.

The carved surface controls how light, air and vision move through the space, while the pattern creates a constantly changing relationship between form and shadow.



SOLID
Structure

The remaining material provides strength, definition and visual rhythm.

VOID
Openness

The openings allow light, air and views to pass through.

SHADOW
Change

The resulting pattern shifts with the position and intensity of light.

LIGHT
Transformation

As light passes through the openings, the geometry is projected into the surrounding space.

THE MAKING OF A JAALI

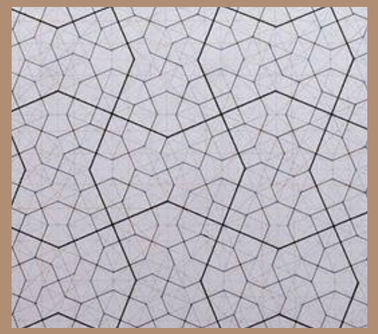
A Jali is not simply a pattern carved into a surface.
Its final form is shaped by a careful relationship between material, tools, craftsmanship, geometry and structural limits.



MATERIAL

Traditionally carved from stone or marble, the choice of material influences the scale, depth and delicacy of the pattern.

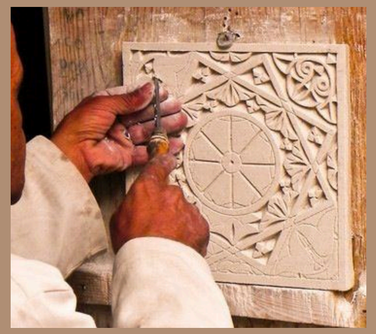
Material determines possibility.



GEOMETRY

The pattern is carefully constructed through symmetry, repetition and proportion.

Geometry determines rhythm.



CARVING

The openings are gradually removed from the solid surface using skilled hand tools and controlled carving.

Craft determines precision.



STRUCTURE

The remaining material must be strong enough to hold the entire pattern together.

Void cannot exist without structure.



LIGHT

The depth, thickness and spacing of the openings affect how light and shadow behave.

Making determines experience.

THE SHANKHA

A SPIRAL CARRIED FROM OCEAN TO ALTAR

The Shankha, or conch shell, is one of the most recognizable sacred objects in Indian tradition.
Its presence extends across temple rituals, daily worship and ceremonial practices, where it is valued not only for its form but also for its distinctive sound.

The Shankha is also one of the four principal emblems associated with Vishnu, alongside the chakra, gada and padma.



MORE THAN A SACRED OBJECT

The significance of the Shankha comes from the way its form, sound and cultural meaning come together.



RITUAL

The Shankha is sounded during puja, temple ceremonies and auspicious occasions, often marking the beginning of a ritual.

Marks a moment of transition.



SOUND

Its natural cavity allows it to function as a wind instrument, producing sound through the movement and resonance of air.

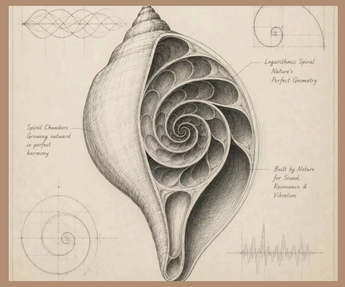
Turns form into experience.



SYMBOLISM

The Shankha is associated with auspiciousness, purity and sacred beginnings in Indian traditions.

Gives the object cultural meaning.



SPIRAL

Its naturally occurring spiral creates a form based on continuous growth and movement inward and outward.

Suggests continuity and cycles.

SHANKHA & SOUND

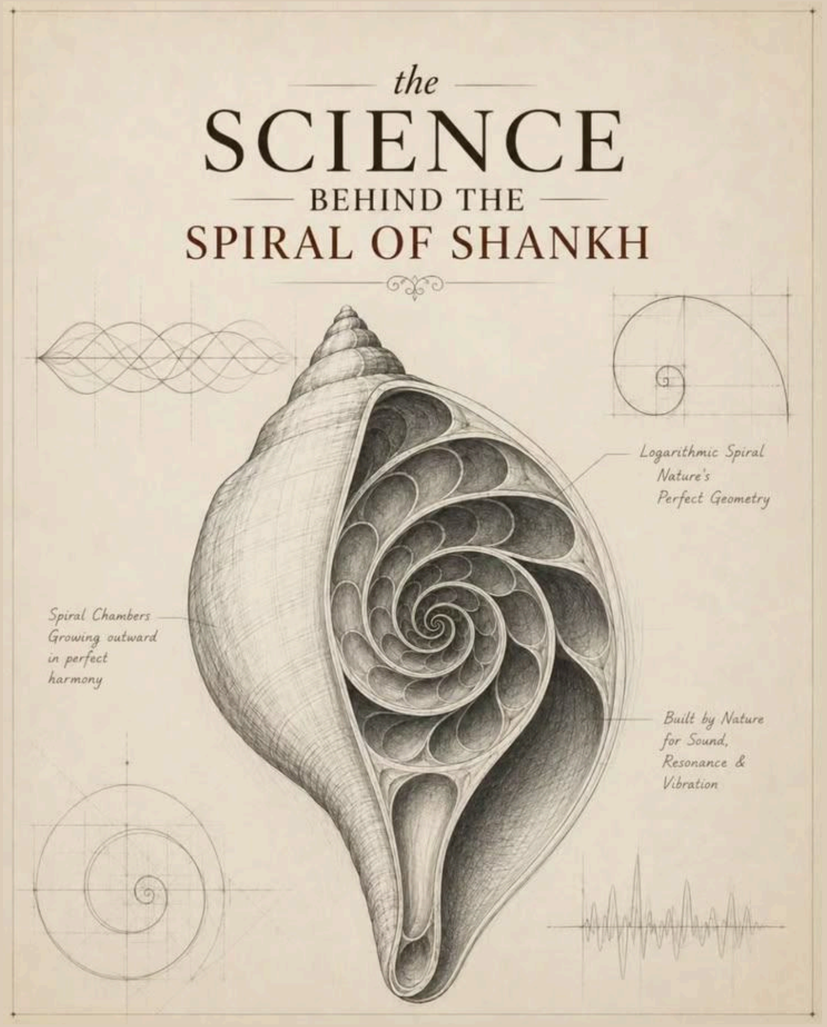
AIR · CAVITY · RESONANCE

The Shankha produces sound through the interaction of air and its naturally formed spiral cavity.

When air is blown through the opening at the apex, it travels through the shell's internal chamber and resonates outward through the wider aperture.

THE SPIRAL ITSELF BECOMES THE INSTRUMENT

IN RITUAL
The Shankha is traditionally sounded at important ritual moments, including dawn and dusk — marking a transition between states of the day.



SHANKHA & TIME

A CLOCK MEASURES TIME. A SHANKHA MARKS A MOMENT.

Unlike a clock, the Shankha does not continuously measure time.
Its sound is used to mark particular moments and transitions — turning an invisible passage of time into an audible experience. In ritual contexts, the conch may be sounded around thresholds such as dawn and dusk, connecting sound with the changing rhythm of the day.



MEASURES

Continuous movement

Hours · Minutes · Seconds

Time is read

MARKS

A specific moment

Beginning · Transition · Ritual

Time is heard



TIME DOES NOT ONLY HAVE TO BE SEEN.
IT CAN ALSO BE HEARD

NATURAL FORM STUDY

Not every reference in this project comes from Indian heritage.
The snail shell is studied as a natural form — an example of how growth, structure and protection can create a coherent form over time.

Spiral

A continuous curve that develops around a central axis.

Movement · Continuity

GROWTH

The shell develops progressively, adding new layers as the organism grows.

Progression · Time

CURVATURE

Its curved geometry creates a compact and naturally balanced structure.

Flow · Balance



LAYERING

Successive growth creates visible layers and changes in scale.

Accumulation · Evolution

PROTECTION

The shell transforms growth into a protective outer structure.

Structure · Shelter

SNAIL & TIME

TIME AS PACE, NOT JUST MEASUREMENT

A snail does not tell us what time it is.
It shows us how time can feel when nothing is rushing it.
Its slow, continuous movement offers a different understanding of time — not as a measurement or a specific moment, but as pace.

FAST MODERN LIFE

Notifications
Deadlines
Constant movement
Instant response



SLOW NATURAL RHYTHM

Pause
Continuity
Gradual movement
Observation

THE THREE WAYS OF EXPERIENCING TIME

Not every reference in this project comes from Indian heritage.
The snail shell is studied as a natural form — an example of how growth, structure and protection can create a coherent form over time.

JAALI

Time is Seen

Light · Shadow · Change

SHANKHA

Time is Heard

Sound · Moment · Ritual

SNAIL

Time is Felt

Pace · Growth · Continuity

DESIGN OPPORTUNITY

How can the visual language of Indian heritage and the forms found in nature be translated into something relevant to contemporary life — without simply reproducing traditional objects?

Design a contemporary object that connects
heritage, natural form and the experience of time.

It should bring together:
Cultural meaning
Natural inspiration
Contemporary aesthetics

Without becoming overtly traditional or simply reproducing heritage.

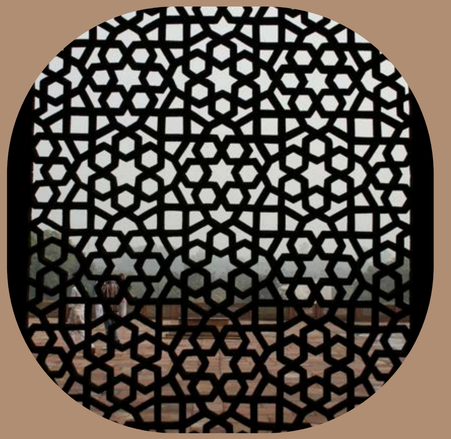
FROM RESEARCH TO FORM



SHANKHA
Sound + Spiral



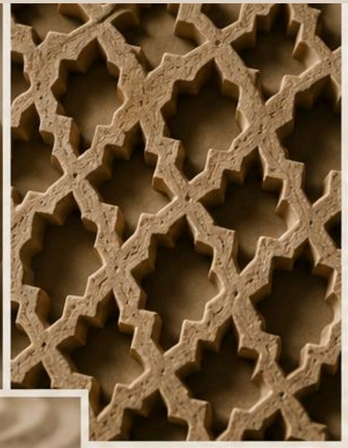
SNAIL / SHELL
Slow Movement + Growth

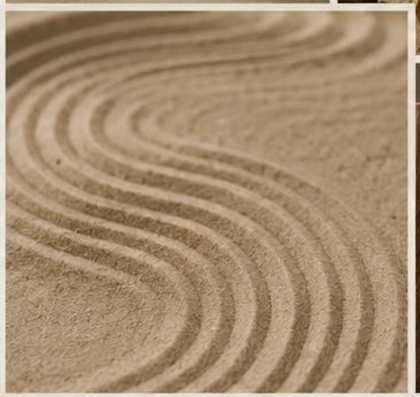
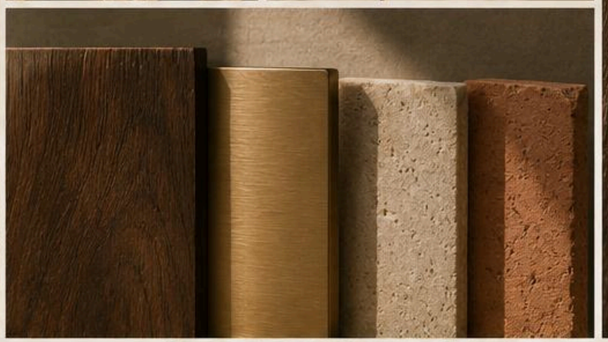


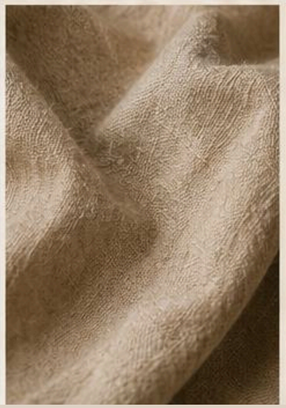
JALI
Light + Pattern

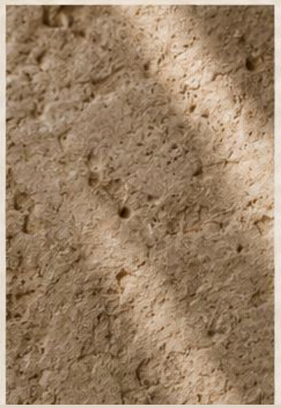
MOOD BOARD



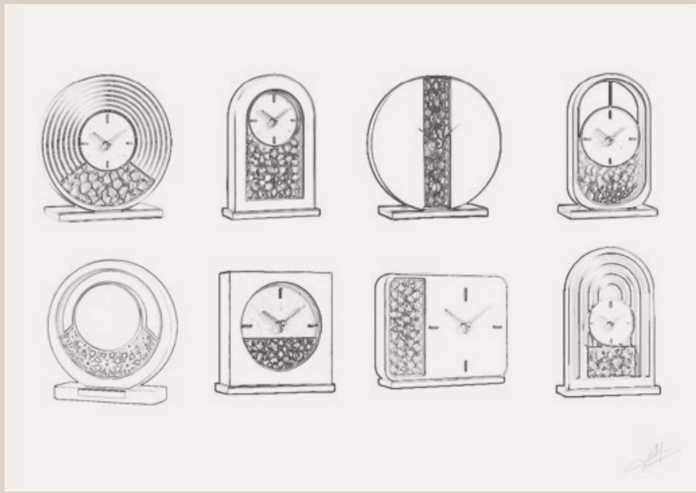


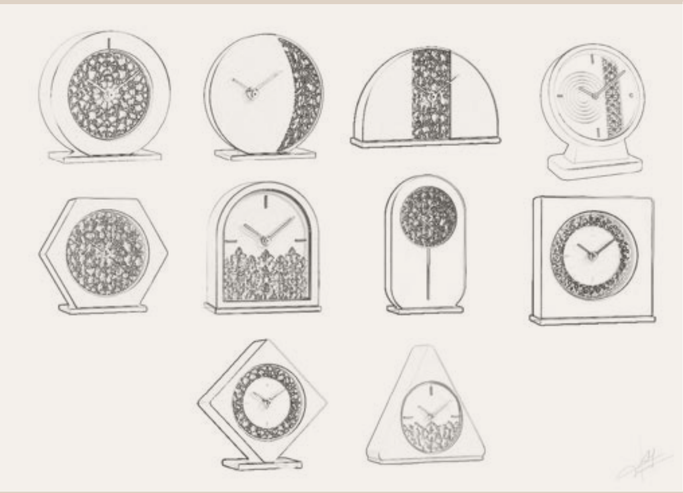




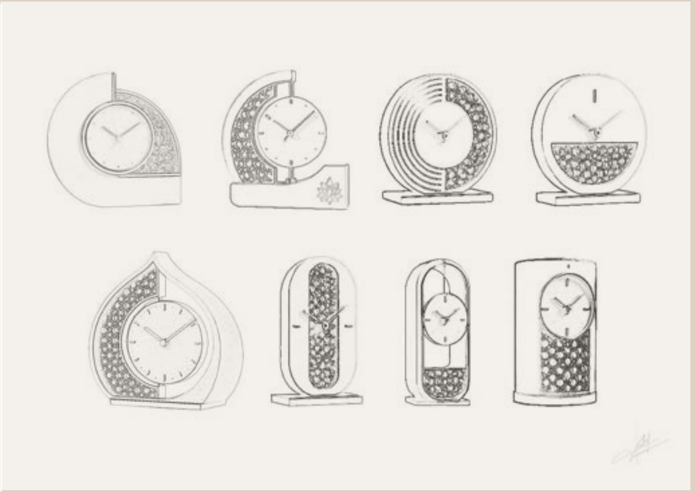





SKETCHES







3D Renders Of Few Selected









SAMAY



Final

PROTOTYPE





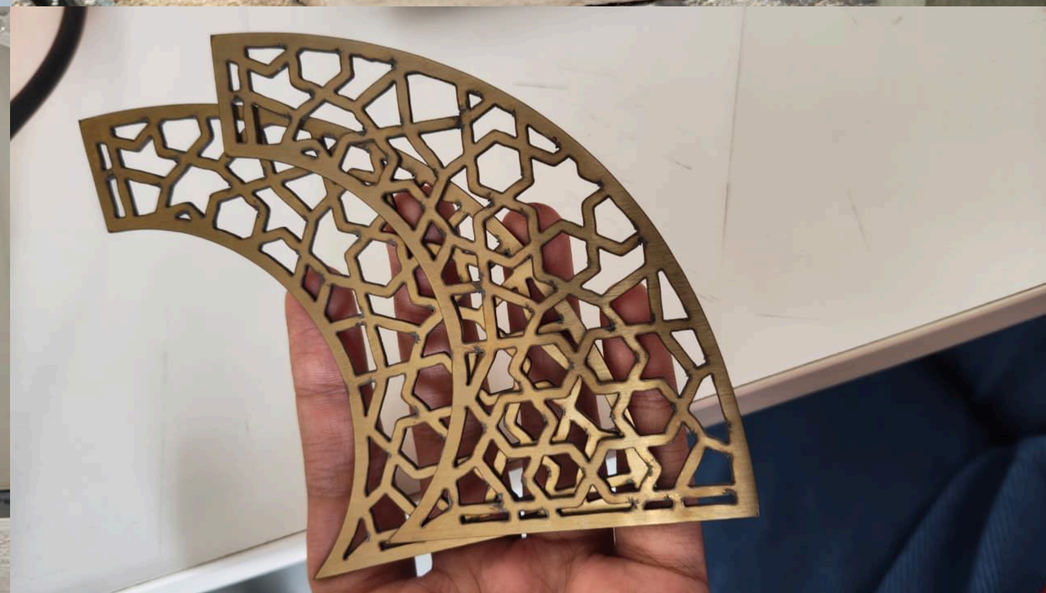


PROCESS



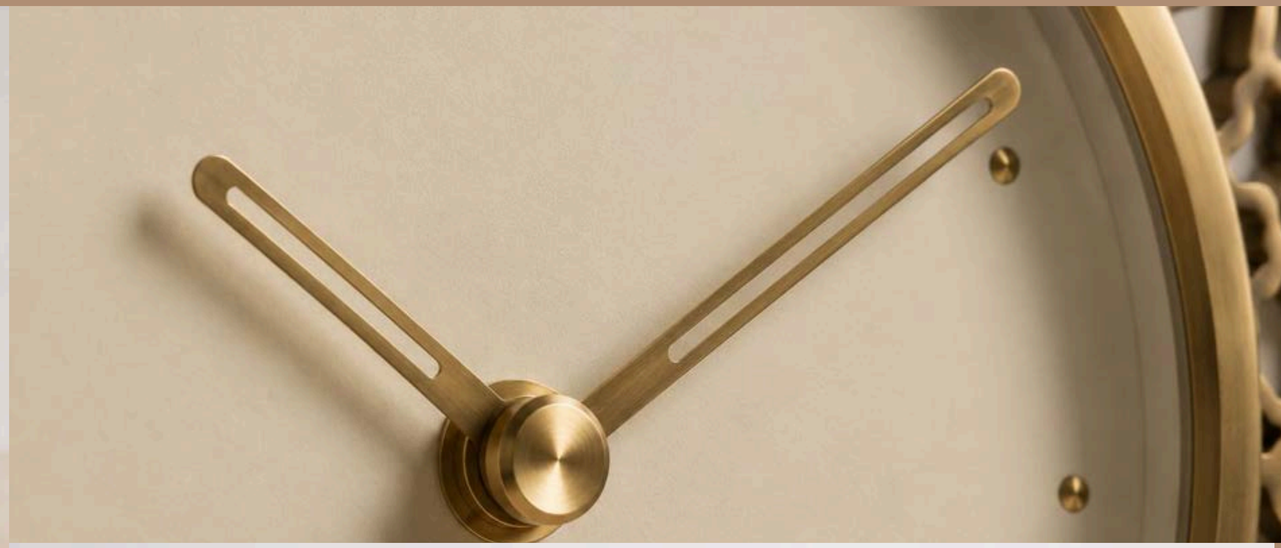






SAMAY











This project taught me to look at heritage beyond aesthetics and understand the principles, stories and experiences embedded within it. I learned to translate cultural and natural references rather than directly replicate them, using Jali to explore light and shadow, the Shankha to understand moments and transitions, and the snail to explore pace and continuity. It also strengthened my understanding of different materials, their properties, handling and manufacturing possibilities, along with experimentation, iteration and prototyping. It helped me understand how material choice and making techniques influence the final form, transforming research into a contemporary product that connects heritage with everyday life.